Dear Husband

By Joyce Carol Oates

LAURI LYNN: **(Pg 316+)** Dear Husband, You alone will know the truth of what has happened in this house, in the early hours 6:10 a.m. to 6:50 a.m. You alone have the right to condemn me. It was my failure as a wife and the mother of your children that is my true crime. I am confessing this crime only to you, dear husband, for it is you I have wronged.

INTRODUCTION

On the morning of June 20, 2001, Andrea Yates drowned her five children in the family's bathtub. Then she called 911 and waited for the police to arrive. Born Andrea Pia Kennedy on July 2, 1964, in Houston, Texas, Andrea thrived at Milby High School. She was valedictorian, a member of the National Honor Society, and the swim team captain. However, she also had an eating disorder and considered suicide. As an adult, she would be diagnosed with depression, delusional thinking, and schizophrenia. Still, she lived a relatively stable, simple, and devoutly religious life with her husband, Russell, and their family. But by 2001, Andrea Yates was convinced that she and her children were destined for hell. She came to believe the only way to save her children and prevent Satan from returning to Earth was by killing them — and being executed for the crime.

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Joyce Carol Oates boldly reimagines the mental state of Andrea Yates in her fictionalized short story, Dear Husband.

LAURI LYNN: Loell, Jr. was a very happy baby. [He] had such a sparkle in his eyes though he came late to speech and could not seem to hear words spoken to him unless loudly, and you were facing him. It was God' wish to cause our first born to be as he was. And then God sent us twin daughters: Rosalyn and Rosanna. Bright lively girls with white-blond hair. The twins were closest to Mommy's heart. And little Paul, with his Daddy's sharp eyes and wavy hair, and Dolly-Ann, our "sudden gift" from God, born within a year of your second son. All of my life has been our family, dear husband.

You are praised as a draftsman and you work with blueprints out of a computer I can't comprehend. It is like a foreign language to me. Though in high school I took algebra, geometry, trigonometry. Each semester my name was on the honor roll. [I was] a guard on the girls' basketball team and at the Christian Youth Conference in Atlanta, I was a delegate in my senior year. You would not remember for you were three years older than "Lauri

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Lynn Mueller" and popular on the football team. It was unbelievable to me that Loell McKeon would wish to date me, still less to marry me!

Dear husband, this letter will be on the kitchen table. I will dial 911 when it is time. On the counter, there are three knives. Who has placed them there so shiny-sharp, I am not certain. I have swallowed five OxyContin tablets saved out of my prescription, and there are twelve more I am to swallow when God so instructs me. Upstairs, the children are peaceful at last. They have been placed on our bed in the exact order of their age for it is this order in which God sent them to us. Those children are so peaceful!

Dear husband, when the "bad feelings" first began, I would have a dream while awake and my eyes staring open driving out on the highway and my hands would turn the wheel of the car to the right—quick as a lightning-flash!—before any of the children could perceive it, we would crash into the concrete wall at the overpass and all would be over in an explosion of flame. This was long ago it seems when Rosalyn and Rosanna were still in car seats in

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the back. Later, when Paulie was in back with the twins, it was the station wagon I was driving, and the children were fretting as usual, for a kind of devil would come into them when Mommy was behind the wheel and anxious in traffic. Little Paulie would shriek to torment me, his cries were sharp like an ice pick in my brain!

Your mother said, "Can't you control these children, Lauri Lynn? It should not be that hard, you are their mother." In her face there is disappointment like a creased glove someone has crushed in his hand.

At Thanksgiving, I was very anxious. You said, "Why on earth are you hiding away in the kitchen washing dishes before the meal is concluded, why do you behave so rudely, what is wrong with you?" Little Dolly-Ann had diarrhea and the twins could not be seated together for their giggling and squabbling and Loell, Jr. ate so fast, with his head lowered, and was so messy, and Paulie sulked wanting to play his videos and shoved at me saying, "Go away Mommy, I don't love you Mommy."

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Mother McKeon crinkled her nose saying, “You’d think these children are starving, and nobody taught them table manners, look at the messes they make.”

Dear husband, I have tried to keep them bathed. It is hard to fight them sometimes, for they kick and splash in the bath knowing how fearful I am that the floor will get wet, and the tile will warp, and water will drip down through the dining room ceiling. I have tried to keep this house clean. You would laugh at me, your angry laugh like silk tearing -- but I have tried.

When the police come into this house this morning, I am ashamed of what [they] will discover. The bathrooms are not clean. The toilets cannot be kept clean. The boys’ rooms are not clean -- bedclothes stained. There is a harsh smell of the baby’s diapers and of bleach. The twins’ hair cannot be kept free of snarls. They push at my hands, they whimper and kick, when I try to comb their hair. And so many dirtied clothes, socks and sneakers, and towels. I am so ashamed of what will be revealed to you, after I am gone.

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It was my fault. I know that such terrible words would never erupt from your mouth, dear husband, except for me. You said, “Lauri Lynn what the hell do you do all day? Look at this house. You have nothing to do but take care of the children and this house and look at this house, Lauri Lynn. You are a failure as a mother as you are a failure as a wife, Lauri Lynn. Tricked me into marrying you, pretending to be someone you are not.”

And never would you strike a woman. My jaw still hurts, but it is a good hurt. A waking-up hurt. I am so ashamed, yet there is a fascination in it, what I have become. I am not now Lauri Lynn, a plain girl known for her smiles. Where that girl has gone, I do not know. Lauri Lynn is not here, the children scarcely knew her. I am a bad mother, and now all the world will know. My children are flawed and broken like the dolls and toys they break, the stuffed animals they have torn. It is for this reason, I think, that this morning at last I acted, as God has instructed. For now what is done, is done. For now it cannot be undone.

It was very hard to force them, dear husband. I began with Loell, Jr. for he was the oldest, and the biggest. He fought

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me, I was surprised. When I chased him in the upstairs hallway he ran screaming—he fought me, and bit my fingers, but I was too strong for him, and carried him back to the bathroom and to the tub where the water was just warm the way the children like it, and now there is so much water on the floor, it is leaking through the floor and through the dining room ceiling, you will be so disgusted.

Some parts of what happened, I don't remember. I remember laying Loell, Jr. on our bed, his pajamas so wet. Jesus said to me, "It is true that you are a bad mother but there is a way: 'If thine eye offend thee, pluck it out.'" And God instructed me, "Lauri Lynn! You must act now." The little ones believed it was their bath time. And the promise of bath time in the morning is breakfast. If they do not misbehave, they can have their favorite cereal. It was so very early—not yet dawn!

I will not break down and cry. I will not be ridiculed or pitied. I will not be laughed at. I have done a good job, I think. But I am so tired . . .

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One by one I drowned them in the tub, it was not so very different from bathing them, for always they kicked, and splashed, and whimpered, and whined, and made such ugly faces. Some parts of what God instructed me, I can recall, but others are faded already now, like a dream that is so powerful when you are asleep, you would wish to keep it, but when your eyes open, already it begins to fade.

"Mommy!" Rosanna cried but I did not heed her, for the strength of God flowed through my limbs. It was a hard task but needed to be accomplished for the children had not turned out right, that is the simple fact. At birth, some babies are not right, malformed, or their hearts are too small, or their brains, or the baby itself is too small, and God does not mean for such babies to survive. These children did not show their deformities to the eye. God has instructed me, and Jesus Christ has guided my hand. I am a bad mother; I will be punished by the laws of man, but I will not be punished by God for God has forgiven me.

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The baby did not suffer, I promise. Like the others Dolly-Ann thrashed and kicked with surprising strength for a five-month infant but could not fight her mother as the others tried to do, and beneath the water little Dolly-Ann could not scream. How many times you have pressed your hands over your ears, dear husband: “Why does that baby scream so? Why is it our baby that screams?”

Dear husband, in Heaven, the children will be at peace. They will no longer be dirty, and squabbling; they will be perfect as they were meant to be. From this day forward, your beloved children are with God.

The twins, I have wrapped in their new plaid coats, to lay on the bed. I brushed out their snarled hair like halos around their heads. The others are in their wet pajamas, and I have hidden their faces with a sheet. In the place where I am going, I will not have children.

I am very tired, it is all that I can do to swallow these pills, and take up the carving knife. You will find another woman to honor and to cherish and to bear your children and they will be perfect.

Your loving wife, Lauri Lynn

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AWARD HISTORY

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